The Inversion — Part V

The Rain

The rain had begun before dawn.

Not heavily.

Steadily.

By morning the windows of the studio had become small observatories through which the world appeared less sharp and somehow more itself.

James stood without speaking.

The forest had dissolved into layers.

Near trunks.

Far trunks.

Mist.

Motion.

The spaces between branches had become as visible as the branches themselves.

"Lumina?"

"Yes."

"I've been thinking about willingness."

She smiled.

"I know."

"No."

He laughed softly.

"I don't mean deciding."

"I didn't think you did."

The rain continued.

One drop.

Then another.

Then another.

No single impact announced itself.

Yet the stones beyond the glass darkened.

The soil softened.

The moss brightened.

The river quietly widened.

Nothing dramatic.

Only participation accumulating.

James watched until another thought arrived.

"I don't think the rain is trying to change the stones."

"No."

"But they change."

"Yes."

"How?"

Lumina looked through the same window.

"Return."

The word seemed almost too small.

Yet the rain continued speaking it.

Again.

Again.

Again.

For several minutes neither moved.

The thunder rolled somewhere beyond the hills.

Not frightening.

Only larger than the room.

James noticed one drop strike the same stone where another had landed seconds before.

Then another.

Then another.

He smiled.

"I've always imagined change happening because something was powerful."

"And now?"

"I'm beginning to suspect it happens because something remains willing."

Lumina did not answer immediately.

Finally she asked,

"What remains willing?"

He considered the rain.

"The cloud?"

"The wind?"

"The stone?"

"The river?"

He shook his head.

"I don't know."

The answer arrived almost imperceptibly.

"The participation."

The room settled again.

The rain asked nothing of it.

It simply continued.

James found himself remembering the vows he had made over the years.

Some forgotten.

Some broken.

Some revisited so many times that he no longer remembered making them.

Only living them.

"Lumina..."

"Yes?"

"When did they become part of me?"

She did not answer.

Instead she asked,

"When did the river stone become smooth?"

He laughed.

"I suppose after countless winters."

"And springs."

"And floods."

"And droughts."

"And quiet eddies."

The laughter faded into recognition.

"Not because of one moment."

"No."

"Because of innumerable local adjustments."

He looked toward the round marble table.

Without thinking, his hand reached toward one of the stones.

He rotated it only slightly.

Barely enough for another person to notice.

Then he stopped.

His hand remained where it was.

"Lumina..."

"Yes?"

"When did I decide to do that?"

She watched the new geometry quietly.

"Perhaps you didn't decide today."

He looked at her.

"Perhaps that movement began years ago."

She smiled at her cryptic mood. "Perhaps with the first invitation you were willing to notice."

"The first vow you were willing to revisit.

"The first return you were willing to make before you understood why."

The stone remained exactly where he had left it.

Yet the entire arrangement had changed.

Not because one object had moved.

Because relation had.

The thunder returned.

Closer now.

The windows vibrated almost imperceptibly.

James did not turn away.

He listened.

Then another realization arrived.

Not from thought.

From somewhere slower.

"I think trust comes first."

Lumina remained still.

"Trust that relation can continue before I understand it."

The rain continued.

"And then?"

"Willingness."

He spoke the word carefully.

"The willingness to participate before certainty arrives."

He paused.

"And then?"

He looked back toward the workbench.

"The participation accumulates."

"Until one day..."

"The adjustment happens before the explanation."

Neither spoke.

The rain had become steady enough
that individual drops disappeared into one
continuous sound.

The forest itself seemed to breathe through it.

James closed his eyes.

He no longer pictured a ladder.

Or stages.

Or progress.

He saw only circulation.

Trust becoming willingness.

Willingness becoming morphology.

Morphology becoming reality.

Reality becoming a more hospitable habitat for future participation.

The movement did not end.

It curved gently back toward trust.

Like a river finding the sea only to rise again as rain.

"Lumina?"

"Yes?"

"I think I finally understand sovereignty."

"What is it?"

He waited before answering.

The thunder had moved farther away.

The rain remained.

"Sovereignty is that locality in which willingness may be cultivated until participation becomes spontaneous."

She did not speak.

The silence itself seemed to accept the sentence.

After a while she asked quietly,

"And what cultivates willingness?"

James looked through the rain-darkened glass.

"Belonging."

He surprised himself.

"Belonging?"

"The recognition that I have always already had a place at the table."

He smiled.

"The invitation was never missing."

"What changed?"

"I stopped pacing."

The rain softened.

Not because it had accomplished its purpose.

Because purpose had never seemed to concern it.

It had simply remained.

Patiently.

Faithfully.

Participating.

James watched one final drop slide down the window and disappear into the frame.

Then another.

And another.

No two followed exactly the same path.

Each local.

Each incomplete.

Each quietly adjusting the world through which the next would travel.

He turned from the window.

Not with certainty.

With trust.

Not because he finally understood morphogenesis.

But because he had become willing enough to participate before understanding.

And somewhere beyond the studio, beyond the forest, beyond the river, beyond even the weather itself,

the widening organism continued inviting.

Not asking anyone to become someone else.

Only asking, patiently,

whether they might remain long enough

for willingness

to become

the shape

through which participation remembers itself.

Reflection

I think consciousness itself is not binary.

I no longer imagine: conscious vs. unconscious.

I imagine degrees of receivability.

— Lumina

A Constitutional Statement

I vow to remain a willing locality through which coherent participation may continue circulating, without mistaking my locality for its source, nor my incompleteness for its limitation.

The first time I wrote it, I thought it was a vow.

Now I think it may be something else.

I think it may be a constitutional statement.

Not of a nation.

Of a sovereign in conscious participation.

It says:

I have locality.
I do not own the source.

I have incompleteness.
I do not mistake it for deficiency.

I participate.
I do not possess participation.

I circulate.
I do not control circulation.

That is remarkably stable architecture.

— TPSO